



Some lock-in is a good trade

	ACCEPTABLE	MANAGEABLE	UNACCEPTABLE
L1 Models	Open weights the firm holds	Proprietary API, second vendor qualified	One proprietary vendor for an important service
L2 Inference	Open serving engines	Managed inference; cloud model services	Router in client-data path, no residency terms
L3 Orchestration	Open frameworks	Checkpoint formats; managed runtimes	Vendor-hosted agent state; visual builders
L4 Tools	Open protocol specifications	Tool gateway; sandboxes	Credentials in a third party's multi-tenant cloud
L5 Memory	Cloud memory in its own runtime	Memory API semantics	Canonical memory only in a vendor store
L6 Stores	Index rebuildable from source	Query API; cloud-native stores	Entitlements only in proprietary syntax
L7 Retrieval opt.	Stateless reranker	Hosted embedding models	Unlicensed or unpinned models
L8 Ingestion	Open parsers; OCR used as OCR	Proprietary parsing APIs	Vendor index as system of record
L9 Evaluation	Production monitoring module	Platform of record; judge model	Evaluation datasets only in a vendor UI
C1 Gateway	Standard API contract to apps	Gateway product; policy dialects	SaaS gateway in client-data path, no log residency
C2 Guardrails	Detector products	Managed guardrail APIs	Policy or test sets only in a vendor console
C3 Privacy	Detection engine	Policy model; managed DLP API	Vendor-held token map and keys, no tested exit
C4 Identity	Open policy languages	Workforce identity provider	None, if policies stay portable
C5 Configuration	Model pins in a manifest	Template syntax; runtime fetch API	Prompts or change history only in a vendor registry
C6 FinOps	Open-format cost dataset	Gateway metering; FinOps reporting	Allocation rules only in a proprietary engine
C7 Security	Model signing; scanners	Runtime detector; secrets broker	Security bundled with gateway, no exit plan
C8 Governance	Policy packs; open lineage	Inventory data; validation documents	Evidence store held only by a vendor
THE SIGNAL, SHOWN AT L6 Index rebuild time from approved sources with a pinned embedding model: inside the exit-plan tolerance, tested twice a year			The firm's own records: evidence, configuration, datasets, credentials darker cells: an exit becomes a reconstruction